

Cover 3: Sky, Buzz, Cloud, and Seattle's Match Version

Three deep, four under: the NFL's most common zone, the three ways a defense rotates into it, the holes every offense knows about, and how Seattle taught it to carry the seams.

First-and-10 near midfield. Before the snap the broadcast's high camera shows one safety, alone, 15 yards deep in the middle of the field. The other safety has walked down to eight yards, just outside the tight end, and stands there like a ninth man in the box. The offense hands the ball to its running back, who runs into a wall: eight defenders near the line against seven blockers, and the one nobody blocked makes the tackle for a yard. Two plays later, same formation, same defense. This time it's a fake handoff, the eight defenders lean forward, and the tight end runs straight up the field past the linebackers. The quarterback drops it in behind them for 28 yards. Same coverage both times, and the analyst says, "That's the deal with Cover 3." What deal? Why would a defense take a safety out of the deep part of the field, where the big plays happen, and leave one man in the middle? Why does the same structure stop the run so well and leak a seam route? And why, for more than a decade, was the most feared defense in the NFL built almost entirely on this one plain-looking coverage? This chapter takes Cover 3 apart: what each defender does, the three ways a defense rotates into it, where the holes are, and the version that taught it to close them.

You'll be able to...

- Draw Cover 3 from memory: who has each of the three deep thirds and each of the four underneath zones, where they line up, and where they go.
- Tell sky, buzz and cloud apart one second after the snap by watching where the rotating defender lands, and say why a defense would choose each one.
- Explain Cover 3's bargain: the extra run defender it buys (the eight-man front) and the holes it pays with (the seams, the curl-flat stretch, the flood, the hitch under a bailing corner).
- Explain how Cover 3 match handles four verticals, what changed when the curl-flat defender became a seam-flat defender, and what offenses attack instead.
- Recognise Cover 3 before the snap from the safeties and corners, and confirm it after the snap by counting deep defenders.

i You'll need

- **The zone map and the shell** (Coverage Fundamentals): a deep third is a third of the field's width, about 18 yards. Underneath, from the sideline in, are the flat (0–7 yards deep, near the sideline), the curl (10–12 yards, between the numbers and the hash), the hook (around the hash, over the tackles) and the hole (the middle, in front of the deep defenders). Zone defenders drop to a landmark. In spot-drop zone they guard a place; in pattern matching they pick up receivers by their routes. MOFC (middle of the field closed) means one safety deep in the middle. A corner who shows press and runs deep at the snap bails.
- **The defense's personnel and the box** (A First Look at Defense): the nickel (five defensive backs) is the everyday package; the box is the area near the line between the offensive tackles (and tight ends) where run defenders stand, and the box count is how many defenders are in it. A one-high shell has one deep safety in the middle. A defender who lines up halfway between the slot receiver and the tackle is in an apex alignment.
- **The routes and concepts aimed at Cover 3** (Dropback Concepts): four verticals sends four receivers deep; flood puts three receivers at three depths on one side; curl-flat puts a curl and a flat route on one defender. A seam runs straight up between the hash and the numbers, a hitch stops and turns back at 5 or 6 yards. Receivers are numbered from the sideline in: #1 is the widest on his side, then #2, then #3.

Reading the diagrams: offense is blue circles (X, H, Y and Z receivers; Q quarterback; R running back; C center; F fullback). Defense is outlined squares: E and T the defensive ends and tackles, M, W and S the Mike, Will and Sam linebackers, \$ the nickel back, CB a cornerback, FS and SS the free and strong safeties. A dashed outline is where a defender lined up before the snap and a dashed orange arrow is where he went; a green ring marks the player to watch. Faint lines across the field are 5 yards apart, starting at the line of scrimmage (the darker blue line), and the small numbers on the left edge give the depth in yards.

Cover 3 in one picture: three deep, four under

Cover 3 is a zone coverage with three deep defenders, each guarding a third of the field's width, and four underneath defenders, each guarding an area in front of them. With four rushers, that's all eleven. The two cornerbacks take the outside thirds, one safety takes the middle third, and the other safety comes down to join three linebackers or nickel backs underneath. That last move, a safety coming down, is what the rest of this chapter is about, and it has a name. Here is the picture with the most common version of it, the sky rotation.

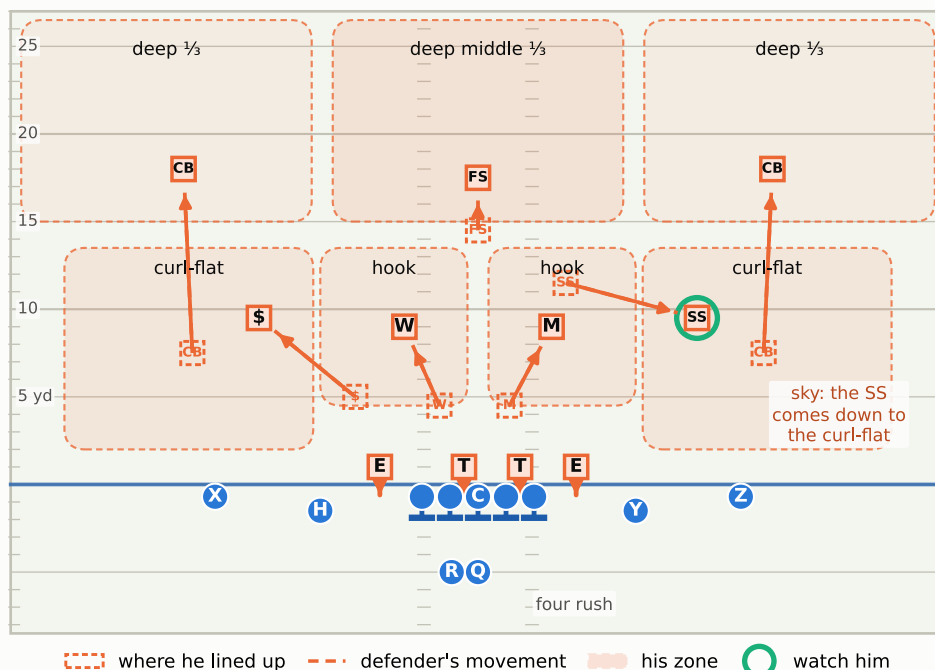


Figure 1: Cover 3 sky against a 2x2 formation (11 personnel: three receivers, a tight end flexed into the right slot). Dashed outlines show where each defender lined up, dashed arrows where he goes at the snap. Deep: the two cornerbacks (CB) bail to the outside thirds and the free safety (FS) sinks to the middle third, about 17 to 18 yards deep. Underneath: the strong safety (SS, ringed) comes down and out to the right curl-flat area (the sky rotation), the nickel (\$) widens to the left curl-flat, and the Mike (M) and Will (W) drop to the hooks. Seven defenders cover, four rush.

Read the picture from the top down, because that's how the coverage is built.

The deep three. Each cornerback has the deep third on his side, from a few yards inside the numbers out to the sideline, and the free safety has the middle third, from hash to hash and a few yards beyond. Their rule is the oldest one in pass defense: *nobody gets behind me*. A Cover 3 corner lines up 7 to 9 yards off his receiver with outside leverage and, at the snap, opens his hips toward the sideline and runs back, keeping the receiver in front of him and his eyes, as much as he can, on the quarterback. He'll give up a five-yard hitch all day. He will not give up the deep ball over his head. The free safety starts 13 to 16 yards deep in the middle and drifts back to 17 or 18, reading the quarterback, ready to break toward whichever side the ball is thrown. He is the *post safety*: the man in the post, where post routes go, and the reason the middle of the field is "closed."

Why three, and why these three? Because a third of the field, about 18 yards, is ground a deep defender can cover comfortably from a good starting spot while the ball is in the air, and because the corners are the defense's best pure cover men and the outside thirds are where a single receiver runs a go route along the sideline. Two deep defenders can split the field too (that's Cover 2), but then each has 27 yards and nobody stands in the deep middle. Three is the fewest that keeps a defender in the post and a defender over each sideline.

The underneath four. That leaves four players for the short and intermediate areas, and there are seven named zones underneath (two flats, two curls, two hooks and the hole). Cover 3 solves the arithmetic the way all zones do, by giving each underneath defender two zones and an order to play them in:

- **The two curl-flat defenders**, one on each side, take the outside underneath areas. Here they are the strong safety on the right and the nickel on the left. A **curl-flat defender** drops toward the curl area, about 10 to 12 yards deep under the outside

receiver, and breaks to the flat when a receiver or the ball goes there. He's the busiest man in the coverage, and the next section is about him.

- **The two hook defenders**, the Mike and Will linebackers here, take the inside areas: they drop to 8 to 10 yards around the hashes, wall off anything crossing the middle, and keep an eye on the running back, who may slip out late. Some staffs call them hook-curl players, because when a receiver runs a curl inside the curl-flat defender, the hook defender widens to take it.

The four rushers don't cover anything, but they're part of the deal. Cover 3 is a four-man-rush coverage. If the defense wants to send a fifth rusher and still play three deep, it has to take one of the underneath four away, and then it's a different call, a three-deep, three-under fire zone, which Zone Blitzes, Fire Zones, and Simulated Pressure builds.

! Why it exists

Cover 3 exists because it is the cheapest way to guard the whole deep field. Three deep defenders, a third each, means nothing goes over the top, and yet one safety is left over to come down and help against the run or underneath. Two-deep coverages (Cover 2, quarters) need two safeties deep; man coverage needs a defender for every receiver. Cover 3 is the middle path: deep security with only three, an extra body near the line, and every underneath defender facing the quarterback, so the ball is always thrown in front of somebody who can see it and tackle.

What it gives up. Four underneath defenders for seven underneath zones, so there are always soft spots, and three deep defenders against an offense that can send four receivers deep. Every hole this chapter draws comes from one of those two numbers.

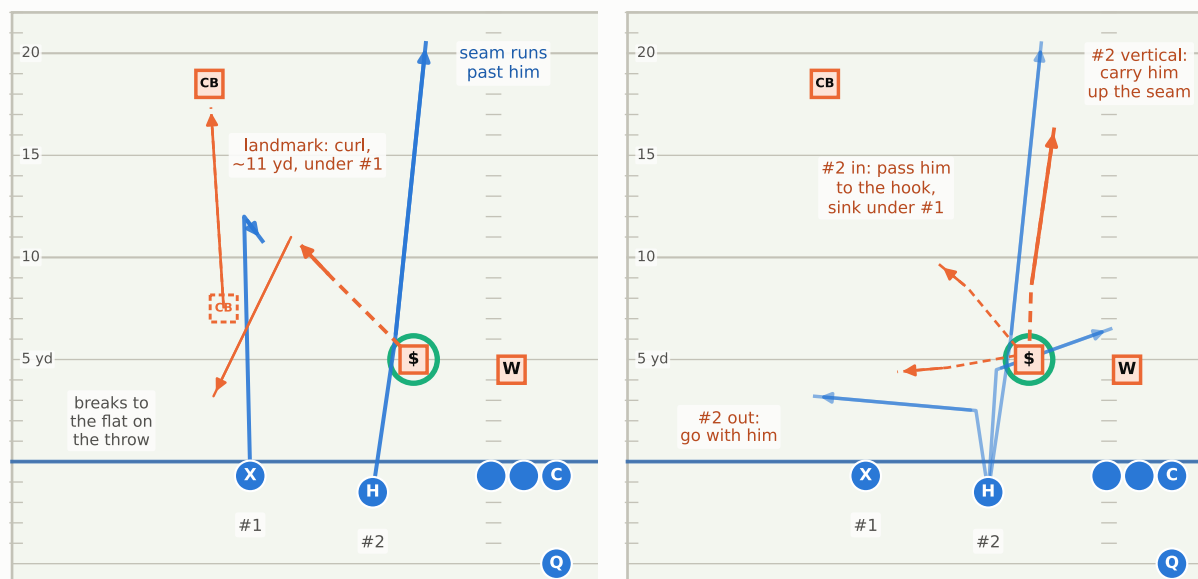
The curl-flat defender, and why he became a seam-flat defender

If you want to understand Cover 3, watch the curl-flat defender. He has the hardest job in the coverage because he has two zones, the curl and the flat, and the offense knows it.

Here is his problem. He lines up a few yards inside the slot receiver, in an apex between the slot and the tackle, because he also has a job against the run. At the snap the outside receiver (#1) is somewhere outside and in front of him, the slot (#2) right in front of him. If #1 runs a curl at 12 yards and #2 runs to the flat at 3 yards, one defender has to cover both: if he sits under the curl, the flat is open; if he jumps the flat, the curl is open behind him. That's the whole idea of the offense's curl-flat concept, and of a dozen others (Dropback Concepts and The Quick Game draw them from the quarterback's side: he reads this one defender and throws away from him).

Coaches handle the problem in two different ways, and the difference is one of the most important in this chapter.

Seam-flat (match): a receiver



The spot-drop answer: play the quarterback. The classic curl-flat defender drops to his landmark, about 10 to 12 yards deep, a few yards inside the outside receiver, and reads the quarterback's eyes. If the quarterback looks at the curl, he's already under it; if the quarterback looks at the flat, he breaks down on it as the ball is thrown, and since he's facing the throw, a quick receiver in the flat should gain only a few yards before he arrives. The coaching phrase is "sink and drive": sink under the curl, drive on the flat. It's simple, it's fast to teach, and it keeps the defender's eyes where they can see a scramble or a throw. Its weakness is everything that runs *past* him. The slot receiver's seam route, straight up the field between the hash and the numbers, is not his business in spot-drop: he lets it go by, and the deep defenders have to deal with it.

The match answer: play the slot receiver first. The other approach changes the order of his jobs. A **seam-flat defender** keys the number 2 receiver from the snap. If #2 goes vertical, the defender *walls* him (gets in his path and pushes him a step outward, legal inside 5 yards) and then *carries* him up the seam, running with him like a man defender until the deep help is over the top. If #2 goes to the flat, the defender goes with him. If #2 goes inside, the defender passes him to the hook defender and only then settles under the outside receiver's curl. Seam first, flat second, curl last.

Why would a defense choose one over the other? Because they lose to different things. The curl-flat defender is beaten by routes that go past him (the seam) or that put two receivers on his two zones at once. The seam-flat defender closes the seam, but he is now following a receiver, so he's beaten by routes that drag him away from his area (a vertical release that pulls him deep while the outside receiver runs a quick out underneath) and by switches, crossing releases in which #1 and #2 trade places at the snap so the defenders' rules have to trade them back at full speed. The seam-flat label is also what you'll hear in fire zones (three under, three deep), where the two outside underneath defenders are called seam-flat players for exactly this reason: with only three underneath, nobody else can protect the seams.

Most NFL Cover 3 today is closer to the seam-flat version, at least against vertical releases. Hold that thought: it's the heart of the four-verticals section below.

Now the payoff. Cover 3 brings one of the two safeties down. Against a passing formation he becomes a curl-flat defender. Against a running formation, he's something more valuable: an **eighth man in the box**.

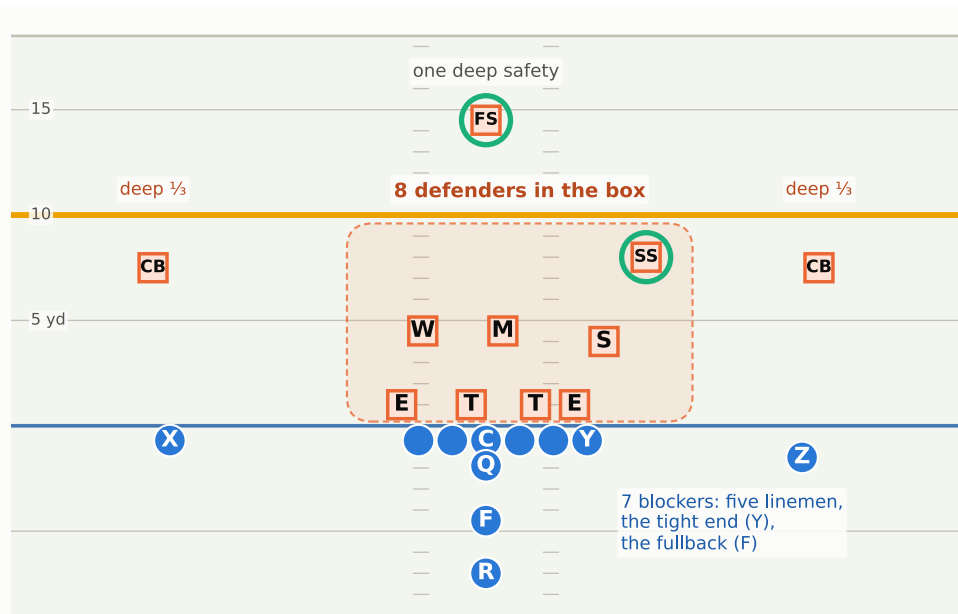


Figure 3: Why Cover 3 is a run defense: a base 4-3 against 21 personnel (two backs, one tight end) in an I-formation. With the free safety (FS) alone in the deep middle, the strong safety (SS, ringed) can stand 8 yards deep just outside the tight end, where he is a run defender first. The shaded box holds eight defenders (four linemen, three linebackers, the SS) against seven possible blockers (five linemen, the tight end Y and the fullback F): one more defender than the offense can block. The two cornerbacks (CB) still have the deep outside thirds, so the deep field stays covered.

The logic is simple arithmetic, and it's the arithmetic of every run game in this book (Run Fits and Box Math builds it properly). An offense has at most five linemen plus whatever tight ends and backs stay in to block. If the defense has more men near the line than the offense has blockers, somebody is unblocked, and an unblocked defender usually makes the tackle. That spare man is the plus-one. Two-high coverages keep both safeties 10 to 14 yards deep, so against a two-back formation they usually play seven against seven, or bring a safety down late. Cover 3 puts him there from the start, and still has three deep.

That down safety also gives the defense a clean answer to the hardest question in run defense: who stops the ball from getting to the outside? In a sky rotation the safety is the force player, the defender whose job is to turn a wide run back inside toward the pursuit. In a buzz rotation he's the alley player, filling the lane between the force player and the box from the inside out. Either way, the coverage and the run fit come from the same call. That's why Cover 3, and its man-coverage cousin Cover 1, were for decades the default on first-and-10: one call that defends the run with eight and still guards the deep ball with three.

The data shows the pattern. On dropbacks charted from 2018 to 2022, Cover 3 was the call on 38 percent of first downs but only 19 percent of third-and-4-to-6 and 19 percent of snaps in the red zone, against 34 percent elsewhere on the field. Defenses reach for it on early downs, when they have to respect the run, and turn to man coverage when the field is short or the down demands a tight cover.¹

¹Course calculation from nflverse `load_pbp()` and `load_participation()`: regular-season plays with `qb_dropback == 1` and a charted `defense_coverage_type`, 2018–2022 (Next Gen Stats charting, about 89,700 dropbacks). Share labelled COVER_3: first down 38.4%; third down with 4–6 to go 19.0%; snaps inside the opponent's 20 19.0%, elsewhere 34.2%. The FTN labels used from 2023 classify far fewer plays as Cover 3 (see Coverage Fundamentals), so these figures are kept within one source. The early-down chart uses first and second downs between the 20-yard lines; “plays of 20+ yards” counts `yards_gained >= 20` on all dropbacks, including sacks and incompletions as non-explosive.

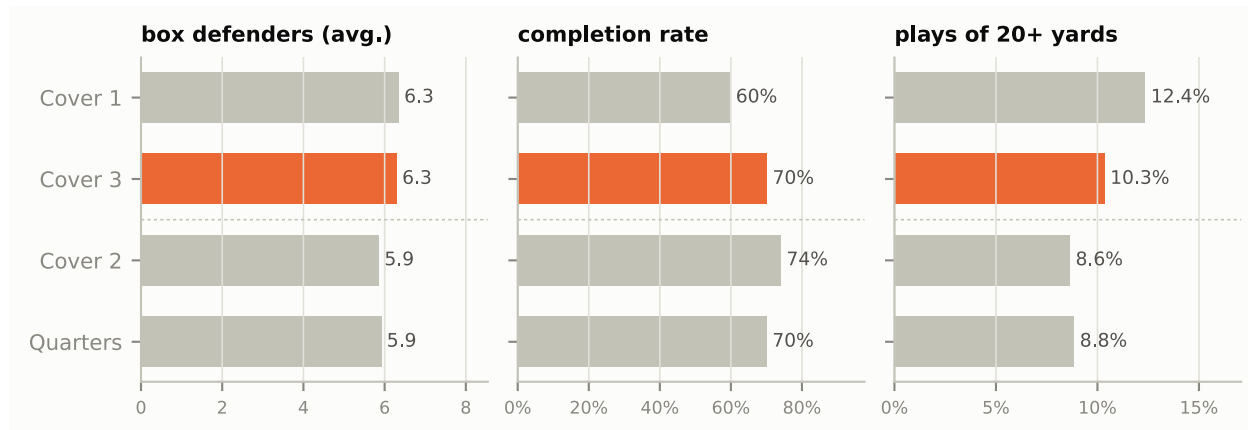


Figure 4: Cover 3’s bargain in numbers: first- and second-down dropbacks between the 20s, 2018–2022 (Next Gen Stats charting via nflverse; about 45,000 plays in these four coverages). Cover 3 (orange) keeps nearly as many defenders in the box as Cover 1 (left) and gives up completions at about the rate of the two-high zones (middle), but more plays of 20 yards or more than either two-high zone (right): the seams and the single safety are the price of the extra man near the line. One-high coverages are the top two bars in each panel, two-high the bottom two.

Read the chart as a trade. Cover 3 puts almost as many defenders near the line as Cover 1 does (about 6.3 per dropback, against fewer than 6 for the two-high zones), because one safety is down. It is still a zone with every underneath defender facing the ball, so completions come at about the two-high rate, mostly in front of the defense. But it gives up more 20-yard plays than either two-high zone: about one dropback in ten, against fewer than one in eleven for Cover 2 and quarters. Those extra explosive plays are the seams and the single safety, the holes the rest of this chapter is about. (These are observational numbers: defenses choose coverages for situations, so this shows what each coverage looks like when teams call it, not what would happen if they swapped one for another.)

🔥 Common misconception

“Three deep defenders means Cover 3 is safe against the deep ball.” It’s safe against a deep ball *along the sideline and down the middle*, where the three deep defenders start. It’s thinnest exactly between them: where one third meets the next, about 9 yards either side of the middle, up the seams. Four receivers going deep against three deep defenders is the oldest Cover 3 problem there is, and the deep defenders can’t solve it alone. The underneath defenders have to help, and how they help is the difference between the 1980s version of the coverage and the modern one.

Sky, buzz and cloud: three ways to get to Cover 3

Very little Cover 3 in the NFL is simply lined up and played. The defense usually *arrives* at it, because the shell it shows before the snap is part of the plan: it wants the quarterback guessing, and it wants its run fits to match the formation. The three classic ways to arrive have names that describe which defender drops into the extra underneath spot, and they come with a handy memory aid: **sky** is the safety to the flat, **cloud** is the corner to the flat, and **buzz** is the safety to the hook, buzzing around inside.

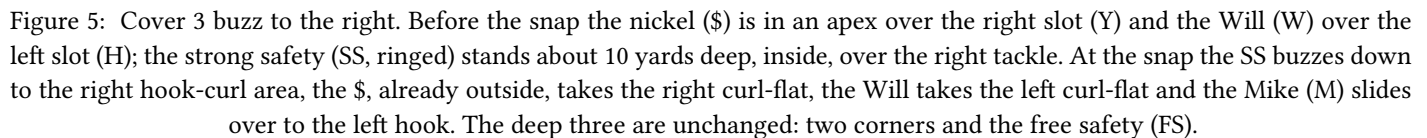
All three end with the same skeleton, three deep and four under. What changes is *who* plays which zone, and that matters because players aren’t interchangeable: a safety coming from depth, a linebacker already outside, and a cornerback already pressing a receiver are each good at different things. (Disguise, Rotation, and Split-Field Coverage shows these rotations launched from a two-high shell at the last instant; here we start each one from the alignment where it is most natural, so you can see what it’s for.)

Sky: the safety takes the flat

The **sky rotation** is the one in the first figure. The safety on the rotation side, usually the strong safety on the side of the formation strength (the tight end or the extra receivers), comes down and out at the snap to become the curl-flat defender. The corner on that side bails to his deep third as usual, and the free safety goes to the middle.

Why sky? Because it puts a safety, a player who is both a good tackler and fast enough to cover, at the point of the field where the run game and the quick passing game meet. Against a run toward him he’s the force player, coming downhill from outside in. Against a pass he’s the curl-flat defender, reading #2 and #1. Teams with a big, physical strong safety (Kam Chancellor in Seattle is the archetype, below) build their defense around this.

Buzz: the safety takes the hook



Why buzz? Three reasons. First, the flat defender is already standing near the flat, so the quick game to that side is covered from the snap instead of from three seconds later. Second, a safety coming down from depth and inside is perfectly placed to wall the slot receiver's seam: he arrives on the inside of it, facing it, which makes buzz a good answer to the seam route that haunts Cover 3. Third, against the run he is the alley player, filling inside the force defender rather than outside him, which suits a safety who is a better downhill tackler than a cover man in space.

What buzz gives up. The defender on the edge is now the nickel or linebacker, usually smaller or slower than the safety, so the force against outside runs is weaker on that side. The linebacker who slides across has a long way to go if the offense runs away from the rotation. And the safety's landing spot, the hook-curl area, is close to where a robber would sit, which makes buzz and Cover 3 robber easy to confuse on a broadcast. The difference: a robber sits in the middle of the field and jumps in-breaking routes, a buzz safety walls the seam on his side and widens to the curl (Man Coverage covers the robber).

Cloud: the corner takes the flat

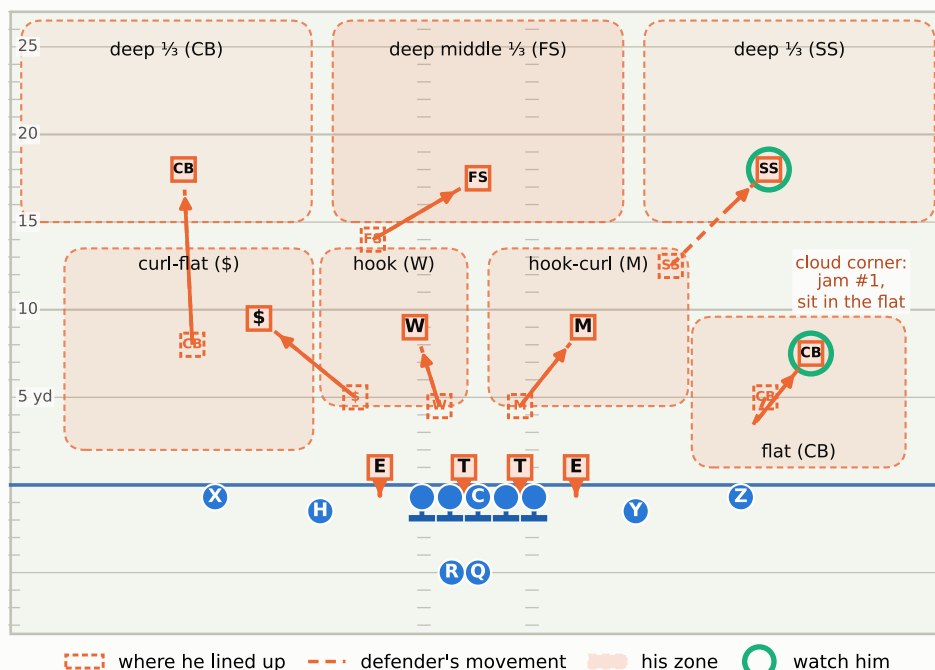


Figure 6: Cover 3 cloud to the right. Before the snap the defense looks two-high: both safeties about 12 to 13 yards deep, and on the right a cornerback (ringed) squatting about 5 yards off Z with outside leverage, the Cover 2 look on that side. The left corner is off, 8 yards deep. At the snap the right corner jams Z and sinks into the flat; the strong safety (SS, ringed) runs to the deep right third behind him, and the free safety (FS) rotates to the deep middle. The left corner bails to his third, the nickel (\$) takes the left curl-flat, the Mike (M) the right hook-curl and the Will (W) the left hook.

The **cloud rotation**, also called a corner rotation, flips the roles of the corner and the safety on one side. The corner stays shallow and plays the flat; the safety on that side takes the deep outside third. On the other side it's ordinary Cover 3, and the other safety still goes to the middle.

Why cloud? Look at the picture before the snap: a corner squatting at 5 yards with a safety deep behind him is exactly what a Cover 2 side looks like, so a cloud rotation is a natural disguise, a two-high shell that becomes three-deep. It also puts the defense's best cover man, already near the receiver, on the quick throws to that side: he can jam #1, re-route him, and sit on the hitch, the quick out and the flat. And it makes him the force player against outside runs, so a defense can cloud to the side where it expects the offense to throw quick or run wide. Defenses like it to the boundary (the short side of the field), where the deep third is narrow enough for a safety to cover.

What cloud gives up. The deep outside third now belongs to a safety, who is usually not as fast or as practised at running with a wide receiver as the corner. A go route by a fast #1 against a safety who started 12 yards deep and several yards inside him is the classic cloud beater, and the smash corner route (a route that breaks toward the sideline behind a squatting corner) attacks exactly the spot between the cloud corner and the safety, just as it does against Cover 2.

! Why it exists: three rotations for one coverage

The problem they solve. A defense wants to play Cover 3 against many formations without telling the quarterback which defender is the extra underneath player, and it wants that player to be the right *kind* of player for the job. Sky puts a safety on the edge (best against the run and the flat), buzz puts a safety inside (best against the seam, and lets an outside defender who's already there take the quick game), and cloud puts a corner on the edge (best against quick throws to #1, and it disguises Cover 3 as Cover 2).

What it costs. Each rotation moves a defender who is good at one thing into a job he's merely adequate at, and each starts from an alignment that leaks a hint: a safety cheating down (sky), a safety inside over the slot with a nickel already outside (buzz), a squatting corner whose opposite corner is off (cloud).

In Madden, “Cover 3 Sky,” “Cover 3 Buzz” and “Cover 3 Cloud” are separate plays on the menu, and you pick one. Real defenses rarely call them that way. The call is usually “three” plus a *rule* for the rotation (“rotate to the strength,” “cloud the boundary,” “buzz to the tight end”), and the players work out the rest from the formation: which side is strong, which is the boundary, where the motion went. That’s why the same call can be sky on one snap and buzz on the next, and why a defensive back’s first job before every play is to say out loud which way the rotation goes.

The holes: where Cover 3 can be hit

Every coverage has soft spots, and Cover 3’s are well known, because it’s been the most common zone in football for decades and offensive coaches have been designing against it the whole time. Most of the concepts in The Quick Game and Dropback Concepts were drawn against a Cover 3 look for exactly that reason. Here are the four places they aim.

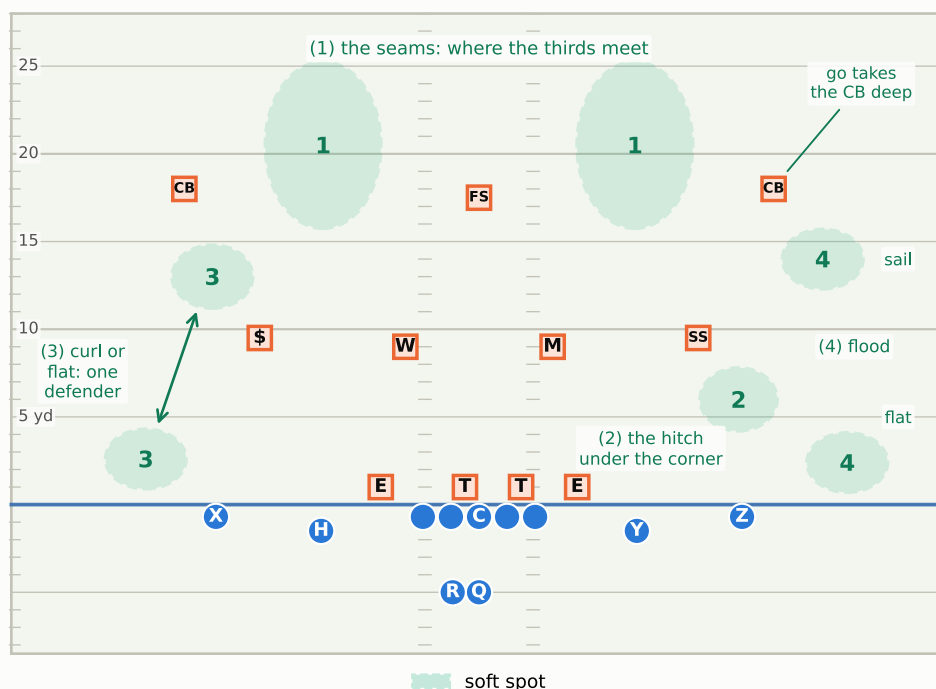


Figure 7: Where Cover 3 can be hit: the defenders at their spot-drop landmarks a second and a half after the snap (sky rotation, as in the first figure), with the four classic soft spots in green. (1) The seams, about 9 yards either side of the middle at 15 to 25 yards, where one deep third meets the next: four verticals puts receivers here. (2) In front of the corners: a corner bailing to his deep third concedes the hitch and the quick out at 5 or 6 yards. (3) The curl-flat stretch: one defender for two zones, the curl behind him and the flat in front of him. (4) The flood: three receivers at three depths on one side (a go route, a sail route at 12 to 15 yards, a flat route) against two defenders, the corner and the curl-flat defender.

1. The seams. The boundaries between the thirds sit about 9 yards either side of the middle of the field, between the hashes and the numbers, which is precisely where a slot receiver or a tight end runs a seam route. A seam thrown 18 to 25 yards downfield lands between a corner who is guarding the sideline and a free safety who is guarding the middle, and if both receivers run seams, the free safety can take only one. This is four verticals’ target, and the next section draws it.

2. In front of the corners. A Cover 3 corner’s first rule is to stay deeper than the deepest receiver in his third, so he bails at the snap. A hitch at 5 or 6 yards, or a quick out, is caught in front of him with the curl-flat defender still several yards inside. It’s not a big play, but it’s a completion every time the defense lets it be, which is why offenses throw it to “keep the defense honest” and why a corner who cheats up to stop it opens the deep ball. This is the trade the coverage makes on purpose: five yards in front of the corner rather than fifty behind him.

3. The curl-flat stretch. The curl-flat defender guards two zones, so two receivers, one in each, force him to choose: the curl-flat concept, slant-flat, stick, snag. The quarterback reads him and throws to the receiver he didn’t take. The hook defenders help on

the curl only if they're not needed elsewhere, which is why offenses add a third route that holds them inside (a check-down by the back or a crossing route).

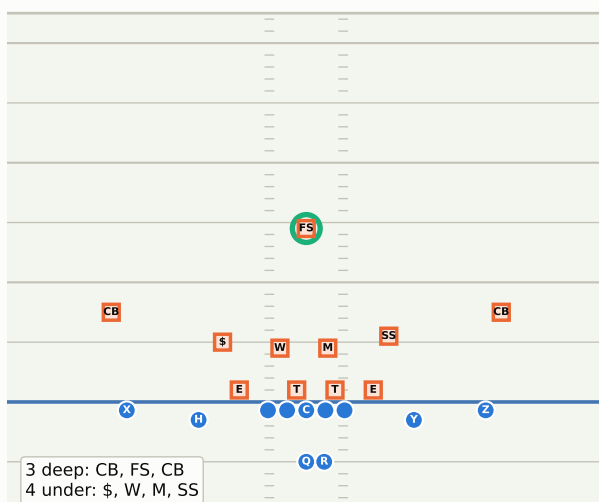
4. The flood. Put three receivers on one side at three depths (a go route that takes the corner deep, a sail or corner route at 12 to 15 yards, a flat route) and there are two defenders to cover them, the corner and the curl-flat defender. One is always open. The sail route, landing behind the curl-flat defender and in front of the bailing corner, is the money throw against spot-drop Cover 3, and some version of flood is in every NFL playbook.

There's a fifth, quieter soft spot you'll hear analysts mention: the window between the hook defender and the curl-flat defender at 10 to 14 yards, where a dig sits down. And there's the run game's answer: a play-action fake that pulls the eight-man front forward and throws behind it, as in this chapter's opening. Cover 3 brought a safety down to stop the run, and play-action punishes exactly that.

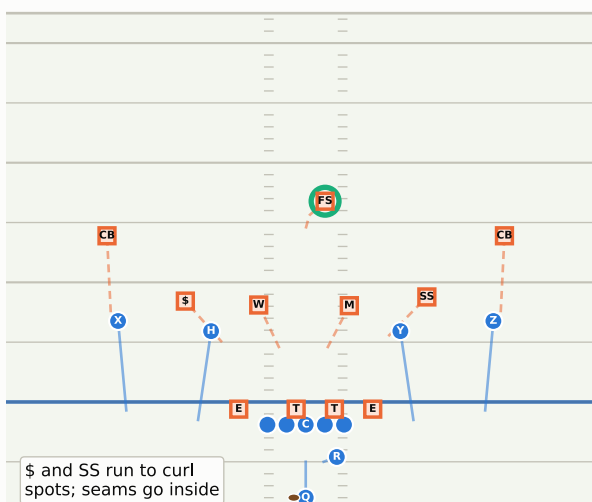
Four verticals: the stress test

Of all these, the seams are the one that shaped the coverage's history, because four verticals is both simple and brutal against a spot-drop Cover 3. The quarterback doesn't need to read the underneath defenders at all; he reads the free safety. Watch it from the defense's side.

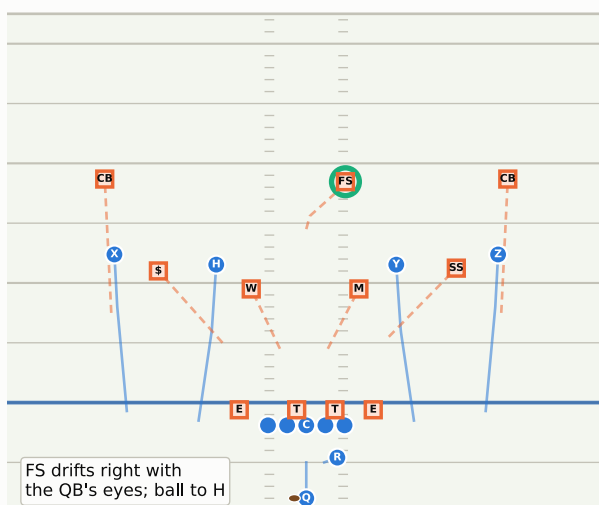
Snap · one-high



+1.0 s · the drops



+1.8 s · the throw



+3.5 s · the catch

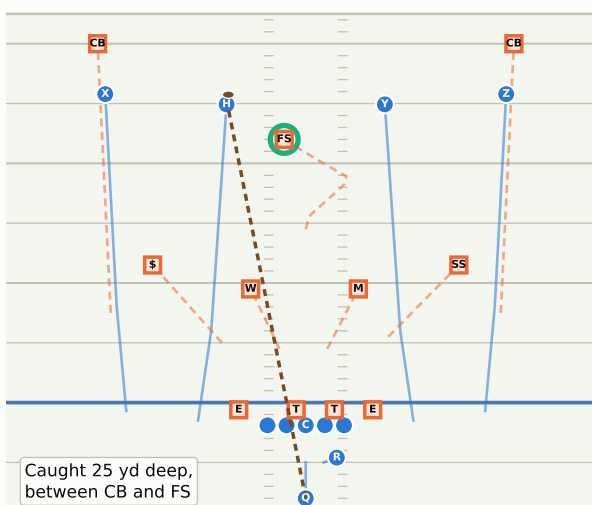


Figure 8: Four verticals against spot-drop Cover 3 (simulated, BDB-format tracking generated by gridiron). The two cornerbacks bail and stay on top of X and Z. The two curl-flat defenders, the nickel (\$) and the strong safety (SS), drop to their curl landmarks, wide and about 11 yards deep, so the seam routes by H and Y run past them on the inside. The free safety (FS, ringed) reads the quarterback, who looks right as he drops; the safety drifts toward Y and the ball goes to H on the left seam, between the corner and the safety, about 25 yards downfield. Every defender did his job; the coverage is one deep defender short. On the web this is a video.

Look at what went wrong, because nothing did. The corners stayed on top of the outside receivers. The curl-flat defenders got to their landmarks. The hook defenders got to theirs. The free safety read the quarterback, as he's coached to, and drifted toward the side the quarterback was looking at. The ball went to the other seam. Spot-drop Cover 3 against four verticals is a math problem the defense loses: four receivers past 15 yards, three defenders back there, and the one in the middle can be moved by the quarterback's eyes. Offensive coaches knew this by the 1980s; the "run-and-shoot" and the BYU passing game of LaVell Edwards made four verticals a staple, and every spread offense since has carried it² (Dropback Concepts tells that history from the offense's side).

There are three ways for the defense to stop it, and each has a price. The safety can guess right (he can't do it every time). The curl-flat defenders can *sink* deeper and narrower, giving the seams a defender underneath for a few steps longer (which opens the flat and the curl in front of them). Or the coverage can stop being a spot-drop zone and start matching the routes.

²The run-and-shoot (Glenn "Tiger" Ellison, popularised by Mouse Davis at Portland State from 1975) and LaVell Edwards's BYU passing game (head coach 1972–2000; 1984 national title) were the college laboratories for the four-receiver vertical passing game: "Run and shoot offense," https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Run_and_shoot_offense; College Football Hall of Fame, LaVell Edwards: <https://cfbhall.com/inductees/lavell-edwards-2004>.

Cover 3 match: carrying the seams

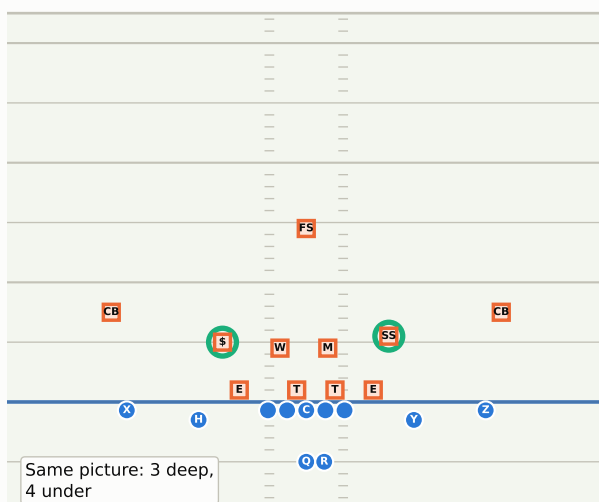
Cover 3 match keeps the Cover 3 shell, three deep and four under, but gives every defender a rule about *which receiver* to take once the routes declare. It is the pattern-matching idea from Coverage Fundamentals applied to Cover 3, and it's the version most NFL teams play today. Nick Saban, building it with Bill Belichick in Cleveland in the early 1990s, is the coach most often credited with turning Cover 3 into a match coverage, and his later college defenses spread the idea; like most origin stories it's disputed, and other staffs built similar rules.³ The rules differ from staff to staff, but the core of most versions fits in a table.

Defender	Reads	Rule (simplified)
Cornerbacks	#1	#1 goes vertical: carry him, on top, like man. #1 breaks short: sink, look for #2 coming outside, then drive on #1.
Seam-flat defenders (\$, SS)	#2, then #1	#2 vertical: wall him, carry him up the seam until the post safety is over the top. #2 out: take him in the flat. #2 in: pass him inside, sink under #1.
Hook defenders (M, W)	#3 (the back), then the crossers	The back releases: take him. No release: wall the crossers and sink into the hole.
Free safety	both #2s, the quarter-back	Stay in the middle third; play over the top of the seam the quarterback looks at, or the deepest route in the middle.

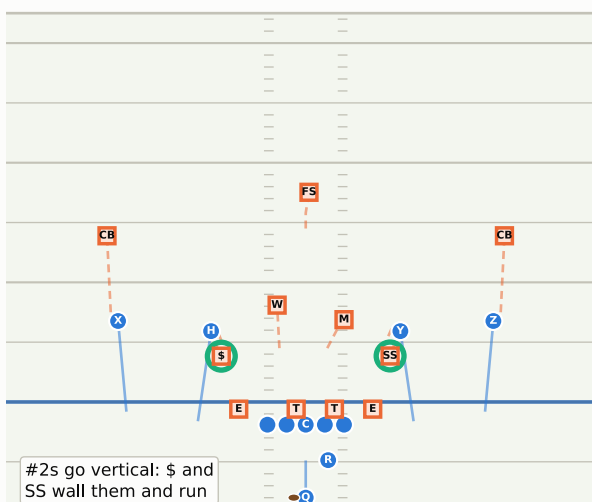
The key line is the seam-flat defender's: *#2 vertical, carry him*. That single rule turns four verticals from a math problem into a matchup.

³Cameron Soran, "The Complete Guide to Nick Saban Coverages at Alabama," Throw Deep Publishing (Feb. 24, 2021): <https://throwdeeppublishing.com/blogs/news/nick-saban-s-alabama-pass-coverages> (a pattern-matching form of Cover 3 that "prior to his association with Belichick with the Browns in the early 1990s simply did not exist"). Saban was Cleveland's defensive coordinator under Belichick from 1991 to 1994 (Eleven Warriors, Mar. 23, 2020, and Saban's Wikipedia coaching record).

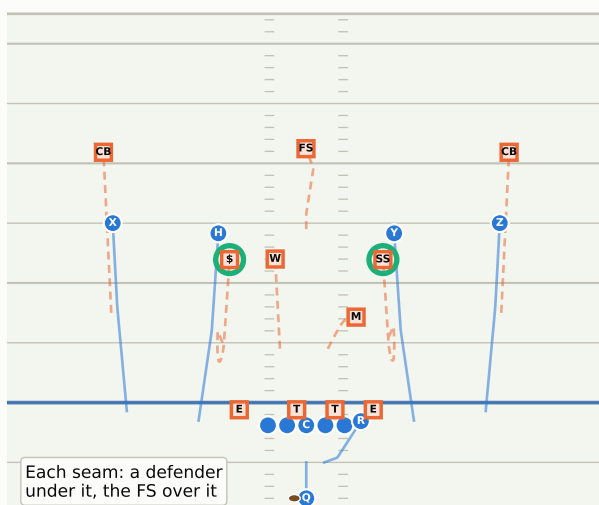
Snap · same shell



+1.0 s · the walls



+2.1 s · the carries



+3.3 s · the check-down

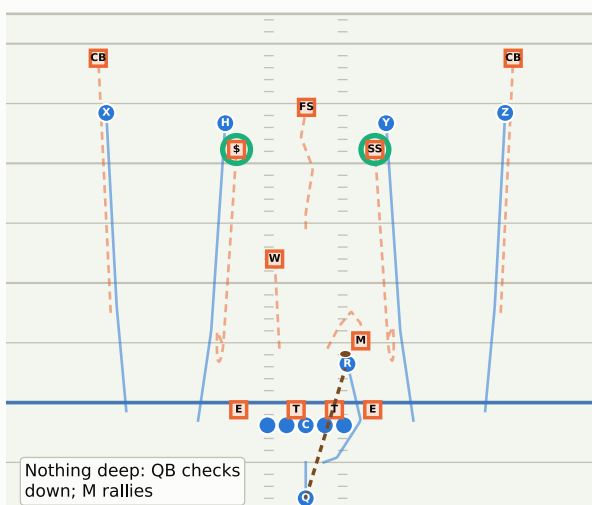


Figure 9: The same four verticals against Cover 3 match (simulated, BDB-format tracking). Now the nickel (\$) and the strong safety (SS), the seam-flat defenders (ringed), read the slot receivers: both go vertical, so each walls his man and carries him up the seam, running underneath and inside him. The corners carry X and Z as before. The free safety (FS) no longer has two seams to himself; he sits in the middle over both carries, ready to help on either. Four vertical routes now face four defenders deep, plus a safety. The quarterback holds the ball and checks down to the back (R) in the flat, where the Mike (M), matched to him, rallies to tackle for a short gain. On the web this is a video.

Compare the second panels of the two plays. In spot-drop, the nickel and the strong safety ran away from the slot receivers toward their curl landmarks. In match, they ran *with* them. That's the whole difference, and it's visible on a broadcast replay if you watch the slot defender for one second. Now each seam has a defender underneath it and the free safety above, a two-on-one in the defense's favour on both sides, and the quarterback who expected one safety and two seams finds nobody open. He checks the ball down for four yards, and on second-and-6 the defense has won the down.

! Why it exists: Cover 3 match

The problem it solves. Spot-drop Cover 3 had a structural problem that no amount of effort fixed: four verticals, and more generally any concept that puts two receivers into one deep defender's area. Matching the routes gives every vertical receiver a defender, without giving up what makes Cover 3 attractive: three deep, the extra man near the line before the snap, and defenders who start out facing the quarterback.

What it gives up. Simplicity, and the empty spaces the carries leave behind. A seam-flat defender running up the field with #2 is not in the flat, so a quick out by #1, or the back releasing to the flat, is open underneath him. And any route combination that makes two defenders' rules collide becomes a target: post-wheel (the corner carries the post inside while the wheel goes up the sideline behind the seam-flat defender), switch releases that cross #1 and #2 at the snap, and motion that changes who is #2 at the last moment. The match coverage's rules close the seams; offensive coaches now design plays to open the gaps between the rules.

The trips problem

Match rules work cleanly against 2x2, two receivers each side. Against 3x1 (trips: three receivers to one side), Cover 3 has a counting problem: four underneath defenders, but three receivers on one side whose routes can all go vertical. If #3, the innermost trips receiver, runs straight up the middle, who carries him? In spot-drop it's the free safety, which leaves the trips side's seam to the corner and the curl-flat defender. Match teams answer with a trips *check*, a pre-planned adjustment. In one common version the backside corner plays the lone receiver on the other side by himself, man to man, and the rest of the defense plays three-deep match toward the trips; Saban's system names its trips checks (one is "Mable"), and every NFL staff has its own.⁴ The tell for a viewer: against trips, look at the backside corner. If he's pressing the single receiver, alone, with no safety leaning his way, the defense has probably checked its Cover 3 to put three-deep rules on the trips side. (Disguise, Rotation, and Split-Field Coverage covers the two-high answers to trips, including rotating to Cover 3 match.)

Seattle's version: Cover 3 as an identity

For most of the 2000s, Cover 3 was something defenses played on early downs between the more fashionable calls. Then Pete Carroll's Seattle Seahawks made it the most feared defense in football, mostly by playing one coverage, with unusual players, better than anyone else.

Carroll had spent decades as a defensive backs coach, coordinator and head coach (with the Jets, the Patriots and the University of Southern California) before Seattle hired him in 2010. His defensive coordinator, Gus Bradley, had been hired the year before and stayed until 2012; Dan Quinn, who coached Seattle's defensive line in 2009 and 2010, came back as coordinator in 2013 and 2014.⁵ Carroll's idea, laid out in his book *Win Forever*, was that a program needs one clearly defined philosophy and should try to do things "better than they have ever been done before."⁶ On defense, that meant a 4-3 front with a one-high safety and Cover 3 behind it, played with five distinctive pieces:

1. **A free safety with rare range.** Earl Thomas, the 14th pick of the 2010 draft, covered the deep middle third alone, and fast enough to arrive at either seam. Cover 3 lives or dies with its post safety; Seattle's could erase mistakes in front of him.
2. **A strong safety built like a linebacker.** Kam Chancellor, a fifth-round pick that same year, listed at 6 feet 3 and 225 pounds, was the eighth man in the box: the sky or buzz player who came down at the snap, the force or alley defender against the run, and a seam-flat defender who could carry a tight end up the field.
3. **Tall, long-armed corners who pressed and bailed.** Richard Sherman (6 feet 3, a fifth-round pick in 2011), Brandon Browner (6 feet 4, signed from the Canadian Football League in 2011) and later Byron Maxwell lined up on receivers' noses, jammed

⁴Soran's guide (cited in the note on Saban above) names Saban's Cover 3 family by call ("3," "3 Buzz," "6," "6 Buzz" and others), with "Rip/Liz" as the rotating safety's declaration of which side he is coming down to. Against 3x1, "Mable" means "the safety is dropping down to the passing strength," and the weak (backside) corner's rule is "MEG: Man Everywhere he Goes," man coverage on the single receiver.

⁵Pro Football Reference coaching pages for Pete Carroll (<https://www.pro-football-reference.com/coaches/CarrPe0.htm>), Gus Bradley (<https://www.pro-football-reference.com/coaches/BradGu0.htm>) and Dan Quinn (<https://www.pro-football-reference.com/coaches/QuinDa0.htm>). Carroll was a defensive backs coach (Buffalo 1984, Minnesota 1985–1989), defensive coordinator (Jets 1990–1993, 49ers 1995–1996) and head coach of the New York Jets (1994), New England Patriots (1997–1999) and USC (2001–2009) before Seattle (2010–2023); Bradley was Seattle's defensive coordinator 2009–2012 (hired Jan. 2009 under Jim Mora); Quinn was Seattle's assistant head coach and defensive line coach 2009–2010, Florida's defensive coordinator 2011–2012, and Seattle's defensive coordinator 2013–2014. PFR blocks automated checks; the dates were confirmed against the coaches' Wikipedia career tables.

⁶Pete Carroll with Yogi Roth and Kristoffer A. Garin, *Win Forever: Live, Work, and Play Like a Champion* (Portfolio, 2010; credits per Penguin Random House: <https://www.penguinrandomhouse.com/books/306479/win-forever-by-pete-carroll-with-yogi-roth-and-kristoffer-a-garin>). The book's core is defining a personal philosophy, with "do things better than they have ever been done before" at the base of Carroll's "Win Forever" pyramid; the link from that philosophy to a small, repeated defensive menu is this chapter's reading.

them inside the 5-yard limit, and then ran with them into their deep thirds using Carroll's "step-kick" press technique, which he had taught for decades.⁷ NFL.com summed the scheme up as "press man, Cover Three."⁸

4. **Match rules on the verticals.** The corners matched #1's vertical stem like man defenders, the down safety matched a seam route from his underneath spot, and the free safety leaned toward the other seam, so four verticals met four defenders. Film analysts who broke the defense down describe it as Cover 3 with match rules on vertical routes rather than a pure spot-drop zone.⁹
5. **Repetition.** With few calls, the players practised the same reads thousands of times, and rarely blew an assignment. The scheme was simple enough to play fast.

The results were extraordinary. Seattle allowed the fewest points in the NFL four seasons running, 2012 to 2015, the first team to do so since the Cleveland Browns of the 1950s.¹⁰ In 2013 the defense led the league in points allowed, yards allowed and takeaways and then held Denver, whose offense had just scored a league-record 606 points, to 8 in a 43–8 win in Super Bowl XLVIII.¹¹

Film room: Seattle Seahawks 2013 — Super Bowl XLVIII

Find any wide shot of Seattle's defense from the 2013 season, and the Super Bowl against Denver is the best place to start. Before the snap: Earl Thomas alone, 14 or 15 yards deep in the middle. Kam Chancellor walked down near the box, often 7 to 9 yards deep on the tight end's side. Sherman (usually on the defense's left, the offense's right) and the other corner up close on the receivers, square, looking like man coverage.

What to notice at the snap. Three things happen in the first second. The corners jam and turn to run, and they run *with* the outside receivers, but toward the deep thirds, not across the field on crossing routes: when a receiver breaks inside, the corner lets him go and sinks. Chancellor comes down: to the flat (sky), or inside to the hook-curl (buzz), and against a run he arrives in the hole like a linebacker. Thomas takes two or three steps back, reads the quarterback, and then breaks on the throw. Denver's receivers repeatedly caught short passes and were tackled immediately, because every underneath defender was facing the ball. That's the bargain from earlier in the chapter played perfectly: concede the short throw, take away everything behind it, and tackle.

The tree

Carroll's assistants took the scheme with them, and for a while Seattle-style Cover 3 was the NFL's fastest-spreading defense. Bradley became the Jacksonville Jaguars' head coach (2013–2016) and then ran the defenses of the Los Angeles Chargers (2017–2020), the Las Vegas Raiders (2021) and the Indianapolis Colts (2022–2024). Quinn became the Atlanta Falcons' head coach in 2015 and took them to Super Bowl LI, then coordinated Dallas's defense (2021–2023) before becoming Washington's head coach in 2024.¹² Robert Saleh, a quality-control assistant in Seattle from 2011 to 2013 and then Bradley's linebackers coach in Jacksonville,

⁷Pro Football Reference draft and player pages: Earl Thomas (2010, round 1, 14th overall), Kam Chancellor (2010, round 5), Richard Sherman (2011, round 5), Byron Maxwell (2011, round 6); Brandon Browner (listed 6–4) signed with Seattle in 2011 after five seasons (2006–2010) with the CFL's Calgary Stampeders. Chancellor listed 6–3, 225 lb; Sherman 6–3 (Wikipedia player pages, which mirror the league listings; spot-check PFR before print). On step-kick: Sheil Kapadia, "Step-kick is one secret to Seahawks' success on defense," ESPN (Oct. 8, 2015): https://www.espn.com/blog/seattle-seahawks/post/_id/14964/step-kick-is-one-secret-to-seahawks-success-on-defense (Carroll traced the technique to watching Hall of Famer Willie Brown teach it, "probably back in 1981 or '82," and has taught it for more than 30 years).

⁸Chris Wesseling, "Why is the Seattle Seahawks' defense great?," NFL.com: <https://www.nfl.com/news/why-is-the-seattle-seahawks-defense-great-0ap3000000464856> (January 2015, the week of Super Bowl XLIX; the piece calls it Seattle's "press man, Cover Three defense").

⁹Matty F. Brown, "Analysis: Kam Chancellor, Super Bowl XLVIII, and How Seahawks Play Cover 3," SI All Seahawks (May 30, 2021): <https://www.si.com/nfl/seahawks/onsi/gm-report/analysis-kam-chancellor-super-bowl-xlvihi-and-how-seahawks-play-cover-3> ("Seattle uses its high safety ... and leans him 60–40 in his middle deep 1/3 to one seam. The down safety ... matches the second seam route from his underneath zone"); Matty Brown, "Soft Sky: How Pete Carroll defends four verts from Middle of the Field Close," USA Football (Mar. 29, 2019): <https://blogs.usafootball.com/blog/7141/soft-sky-how-pete-carroll-defends-four-verts-from-middle-of-the-field-close> (the corners press in "read 1/3" technique and run with a vertical release). The precise rules changed by opponent and season; this is a summary of the common thread.

¹⁰Pro Football Reference team pages, Seattle Seahawks 2012–2015 (fewest points allowed in the league each season: <https://www.pro-football-reference.com/teams/sea/2015.htm> and the 2012–2014 pages); Associated Press, "Seahawks extend streak with fewest points allowed to four years" (Jan. 2016, via Fox Sports: <https://www.foxnews.com/sports/seahawks-extend-streak-with-fewest-points-allowed-to-four-years>): 15.3, 14.4, 15.9 and 17.3 points per game, the first team of the Super Bowl era to do it and the second ever, after the 1953–57 Cleveland Browns (five straight).

¹¹"2013 Seattle Seahawks season," Wikipedia: https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/2013_Seattle_Seahawks_season (first in points allowed, yards allowed and takeaways; Super Bowl XLVIII, Seattle 43, Denver 8, Feb. 2, 2014); "2013 Denver Broncos season": https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/2013_Denver_Broncos_season (606 points, an NFL single-season record). Spot-check on Pro Football Reference before print.

¹²Pro Football Reference coaching pages for Bradley and Quinn cited above: Bradley, Jacksonville head coach 2013–2016, Chargers defensive coordinator 2017–2020, Raiders 2021, Colts 2022–2024; Quinn, Atlanta head coach 2015–2020 (Super Bowl LI, a 34–28 overtime loss to New England, Feb. 5, 2017), Dallas defensive coordinator 2021–2023, Washington head coach from 2024 and still in 2026. Bradley was fired by the Colts on Jan. 6, 2025, spent 2025 as the 49ers' assistant head coach, and was hired as Tennessee's defensive coordinator under Saleh on Feb. 4, 2026 (Titans.com: <https://www.tennesseetitans.com/news/titans-hire-gus-bradley-as-defensive-coordinator>). Status checked against Wikipedia, Oct. 2026.

built his first San Francisco defenses (he was the 49ers' coordinator from 2017 to 2020) on the same eight-man-front, press-bail Cover 3, before mixing in more coverages from 2019 on.¹³ The tree is still growing: Saleh, the Tennessee Titans' head coach in 2026, hired Bradley as his defensive coordinator.

You can follow the coaches through the data. Bradley is the clearest case, because he moved three times in five years.

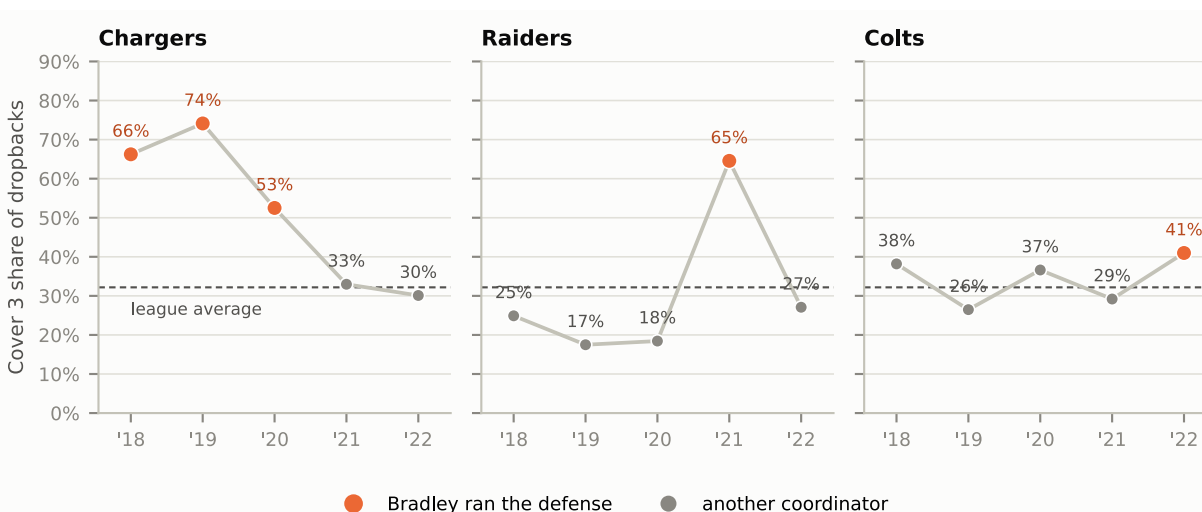


Figure 10: Follow the coach: the share of each defense's charted dropbacks played in Cover 3, 2018–2022 (Next Gen Stats charting via nflverse). Orange points are seasons in which Gus Bradley, Seattle's defensive coordinator from 2009 to 2012, ran that defense; grey points are seasons he didn't. The dashed line is the league average (32 percent). Bradley's 2019 and 2018 Chargers and his 2021 Raiders posted the three highest Cover 3 rates of any defense in this period (his 2020 Chargers were sixth), and the Raiders' rate jumped from 18 to 65 percent the year he arrived and fell back to 27 percent the year he left.

The pattern is hard to miss. The 2019 Chargers played Cover 3 on 74 percent of their charted dropbacks, the highest rate of any defense from 2018 to 2022; the 2018 Chargers and the 2021 Raiders were second and third. When Bradley left Los Angeles the Chargers fell to the league average; when he arrived in Las Vegas the Raiders more than tripled their rate; when he left, it fell back. Coaches are their schemes, and a coverage this simple travels well. (Not every member of the tree stayed with it: Quinn's 2021 Cowboys played Cover 3 on about 27 percent of their dropbacks, below the league average, part of a broader shift you'll see next.)

i Film room: Los Angeles Chargers 2019 and Las Vegas Raiders 2021 — the coverage in the numbers

If you want to see Seattle's Cover 3 without Seattle's players, Bradley's Chargers are the best library: a single-high safety, corners off and turned in, a safety rotating down to the strong side on nearly every early down (by the same nflverse count, Cover 3 on about 82 percent of their charted first- and second-down dropbacks in 2019), and the same handful of rotations week after week. The 2021 Raiders are the controlled experiment: a different roster, a new coordinator, and within one season their coverage mix looks like the Chargers'.

What to notice: how few different pictures the defense shows. That is the Carroll philosophy, and it has a modern cost: an offense that knows the coverage before the snap can call the concept that beats it. In the same years, Vic Fangio's two-high defenses were showing quarterbacks a different picture on every snap (Coverage Fundamentals tells that story), and the league's split-safety rate climbed every year. The fact that Cover 3 was still the most-charted single coverage in the NFL in 2025 says that the simple version keeps working;¹⁴ the fact that it's now usually disguised says what changed.

¹³Robert Saleh's career (Seattle defensive quality control 2011–2013, Jacksonville linebackers coach 2014–2016, 49ers defensive coordinator 2017–2020 and again in 2025, Titans head coach 2026): Wikipedia and the Titans' Bradley announcement cited in the note on the tree. Nick Wagoner, "In copycat league, 49ers hope to replicate Seahawks' defensive success," ESPN (Sept. 15, 2017): https://www.espn.com/blog/san-francisco-49ers/post/_id/27264/in-copycat-league-49ers-hope-to-replicate-seattles-defensive-success; Grant Cohn, "How the 49ers Defense will Change in 2020," SI (May 25, 2020): <https://www.si.com/nfl/49ers/news/how-the-49ers-defense-will-change-in-2020> (2017–18: "Cover 3 to stop the pass"; 2019: coverages "varied and disguised"). In the nflverse count used in this chapter, the 2018 49ers played Cover 3 on 51% of charted dropbacks (eighth-highest of 160 team-seasons, 2018–2022) and the 2020 49ers on 28%.

¹⁴Course calculation from nflverse participation data (FTN charting), regular-season dropbacks with a coverage label, 2025: COVER_3 27.7%, COVER_2 22.9%, COVER_1 22.4%. In the Next Gen Stats labels for 2018–2022, Cover 3 was the most common label in four of the five seasons (Cover 1 edged it in 2019); in FTN's 2023 and 2024 labels Cover 1 led. Treat the labels as estimates (see Coverage Fundamentals).

The coach who made it famous has moved on too. Carroll coached Seattle through the 2023 season and the Raiders in 2025, when they went 3–14 and dismissed him after one year. Seattle won Super Bowl LX in February 2026 under Mike Macdonald, with a split-safety defense from a different school (from Week 14 through the Super Bowl, two-high coverage on 54.8 percent of pass plays) (Fangio’s Two-High Revolution and Macdonald’s Answer).¹⁵ But nearly every NFL defense still plays Cover 3 on some early downs, usually as a match coverage, usually arrived at by one of the three rotations above. The Seattle version didn’t disappear; it became part of everyone’s playbook.

Recognising Cover 3: before and after the snap

Everything above adds up to a two-step read you can make from your couch. First the hypothesis, before the snap; then the test, one second after it.

Before the snap: the Cover 3 look.

- **One safety deep in the middle**, 13 to 16 yards, roughly over the ball: middle of the field closed. That says Cover 3 or Cover 1.
- **The corners off and turned in**, 7 to 9 yards from their receivers with outside leverage, shoulders angled toward the quarterback. Cover 1 corners are more often pressed and square to their men. (Seattle-style corners who press and bail are the exception, and you check them after the snap.)
- **A safety down near the box**, 7 to 10 yards deep on the tight end’s side or over a slot: the likely sky or buzz player. Where he stands hints at which: outside the slot or the tight end suggests sky, inside over the slot with a nickel outside suggests buzz.
- **Underneath defenders in apex alignments**, a few yards inside the slot receivers, not tight on them: zone, not man.
- **The cloud tell**: a two-high look in which only *one* corner squats at 5 yards and the other is off. A real Cover 2 usually squats both. (Asymmetry is also how Cover 6 looks, so check after the snap.)

After the snap: count the deep defenders. One second after the snap, look at the deep part of the field and count. Three defenders backedpalling or running away from the line, spread across the width, means a Cover 3 family call: Cover 3, or a three-deep fire zone. Two means Cover 2 or one of its relatives; four means quarters; one means Cover 1 or a robber. Then look underneath:

- **Did the corners run to the deep thirds or chase receivers?** Corners who keep their eyes inside and stay deep as their receivers break short are zone. Corners who turn and follow their receiver across the field are man (Cover 1).
- **Which defender rotated?** A safety into the flat is sky, a safety into the hook-curl is buzz, a corner sitting in the flat with a safety running over him is cloud.
- **What did the slot defenders do with a vertical release?** Ran away to a spot: spot-drop. Ran with him up the seam: match.
- **How many rushed?** Four rushers and three deep is Cover 3. Five rushers and three deep, with a defensive lineman dropping into coverage, is a fire zone (Zone Blitzes, Fire Zones, and Simulated Pressure).

💡 Watch for it on Sunday: count to three

For one quarter, on every passing down:

- **Before the snap**: one safety deep in the middle? Corners off and turned in? A safety walked down near the box? If yes to all three, say “Cover 3” and guess the rotation from the down safety: outside (sky) or inside with a nickel outside (buzz). If you see two-high with only one squatting corner, say “cloud?”
- **One second after the snap, count deep defenders.** Three means the Cover 3 family. Say which defender became the extra underneath player.
- **Watch one slot defender against a vertical release.** Away to a spot (spot-drop) or up the seam with him (match)?
- **Find the ball.** If it’s completed, where? A hitch in front of a bailing corner, a seam between the thirds, a sail behind the curl-flat defender, or a check-down in front of everyone? On the replay, find the defender whose job that area was.
- **On early downs, count the box.** Seven or eight near the line with one safety deep is Cover 3’s run defense working. Watch for the play-action pass that tries to punish it.

¹⁵Course fact sheet (planning/FACTS-current.md, checked Oct. 2026): Raiders 2025, Pete Carroll fired after one season (3–14); Super Bowl LX, Feb. 8, 2026, Seahawks 29, Patriots 13, Seattle head coach Mike Macdonald. Seattle’s two-high rate from Week 14 through Super Bowl LX (54.8%, highest of any playoff team): NFL.com Next Gen Stats, “The coverage that turned the Seahawks into Super Bowl winners”: <https://www.nfl.com/news/the-coverage-that-turned-the-seahawks-into-super-bowl-winners-and-is-taking-the-nfl-by-storm>. Carroll’s Seattle tenure (2010–2023): Pro Football Reference coaching page cited above.

i Go deeper: Cover 3 in real tracking data

The NFL's Big Data Bowl files (no download is bundled with this book) label each play's coverage, so you can find real Cover 3 plays and draw them with the same code. A sketch (the code is in the web version), assuming the 2025 edition's `plays.csv` and tracking files in `data/bdb/`:

The diagrams in this chapter are simulated in the same format (`Play.to_tracking()`), which is why the two draw identically.

Predict the play

? Predict the play 1: first-and-10, two tight ends

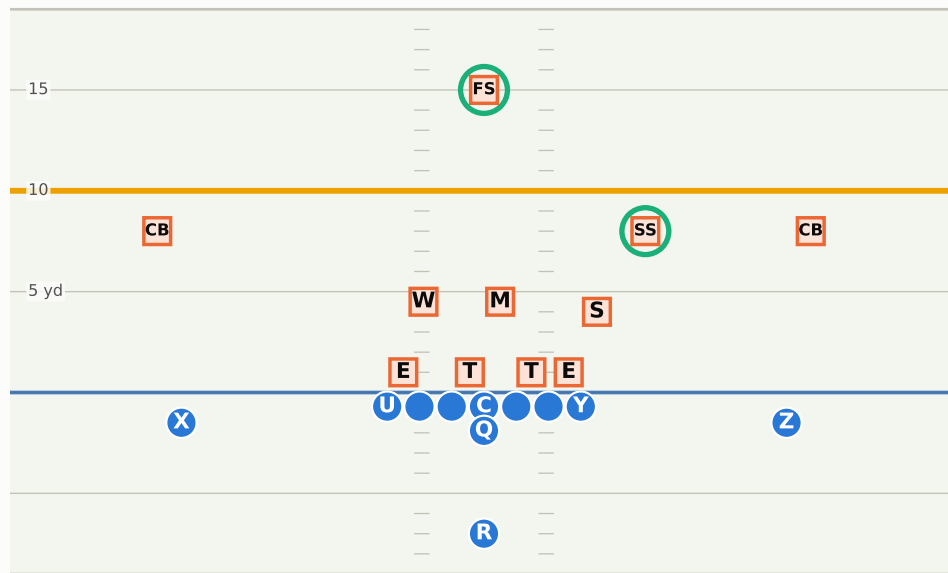


Figure 11: First-and-10, ball in the middle, 12 personnel (two tight ends, Y and U, attached to the line; X and Z split wide). The defense is in its base 4-3. One safety (FS) is 15 yards deep in the middle; the strong safety (SS) is 8 yards deep, about 3 yards outside the right tight end; both corners (CB) are 8 yards off with outside leverage. The safeties are ringed.

What coverage family is this, what will the strong safety do at the snap, and if the offense wants to throw, where should it aim?

Answer 1 is at the end of the chapter. Try it first.

💡 Predict the play 2: two-high, but the corners don't match

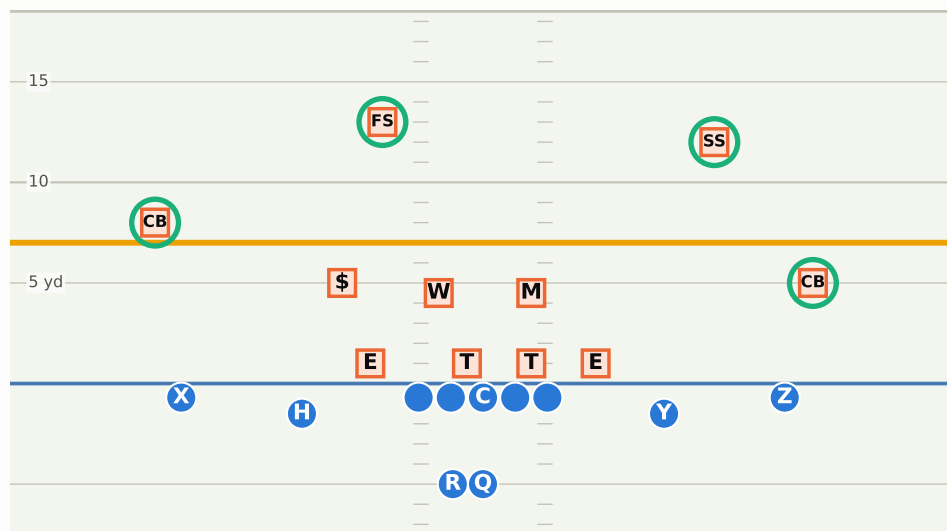


Figure 12: Second-and-7 against 11 personnel in a 2x2. Two safeties deep: the free safety (FS) 13 yards deep, about 5 yards left of the ball, the strong safety (SS) 12 yards deep, between the right hash and the numbers. The right cornerback is squatting about 5 yards off Z with outside leverage; the left cornerback is 8 yards off X. The nickel (\$) is in an apex over the left slot.

Both corners and both safeties are ringed.

The shell says two-high. What else could it be, which corner gives it away, and what will you check one second after the snap?

Answer 2 is at the end of the chapter. Try it first.

💡 Predict the play 3: two seconds after the snap

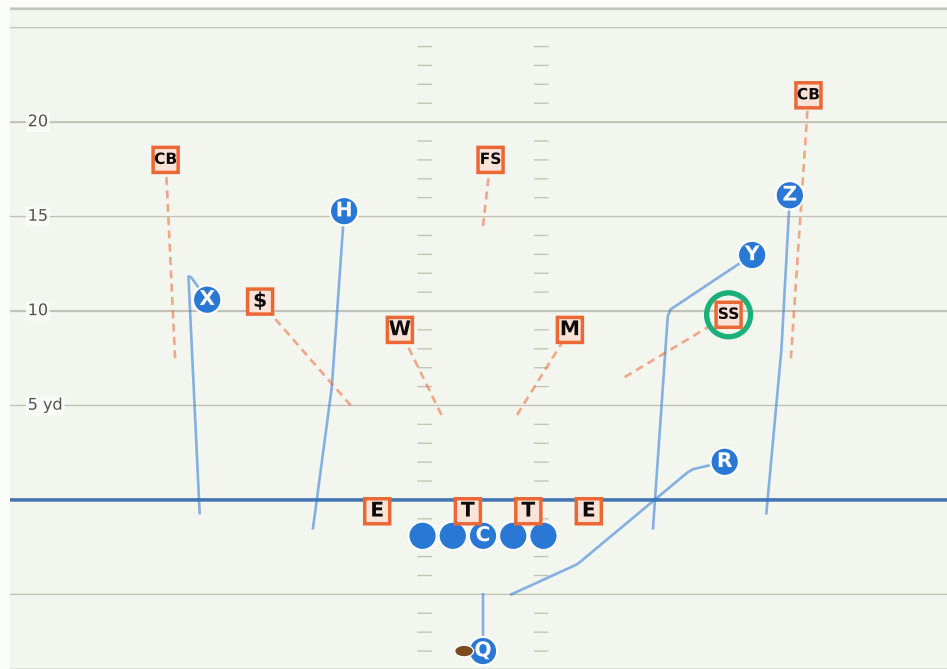


Figure 13: A Cover 3 sky play against a flood to the right, 2.2 seconds after the snap (simulated). Faint lines are where each player has been. Z is running a go route with the right cornerback over him; Y, from the slot, has pushed upfield and is breaking toward the sideline at about 12 yards (a sail route); the back (R) is running to the right flat. The strong safety (SS, ringed) is the curl-flat defender on that side. On the left, X and H run to hold the nickel (\$), the Will and the free safety.

Who's the quarterback's read, what has that defender done, and where does the ball go?

Answer 3 is at the end of the chapter. Try it first.

Takeaways

- **Cover 3 is three deep and four under.** The corners take the outside thirds and a safety the middle; two curl-flat defenders and two hook defenders take the underneath areas; four rush. It guards the whole deep field with only three players, which is why it's the NFL's most common zone.
- **Its bargain is the eighth man.** Bringing the second safety down gives the defense an extra run defender (and its force or alley player) while still playing three deep. The price is the seams, the soft spots in front of the corners, and an underneath defender with two zones.
- **Sky, buzz and cloud are three ways to arrive at the same coverage.** Sky sends a safety to the curl-flat, buzz sends him inside to the hook-curl while an outside defender takes the flat, and cloud puts the corner in the flat with a safety over him. Each fits a different player to the job and leaks a different pre-snap tell.
- **The curl-flat defender is the key, and the match version changed his job.** In spot-drop he guards a place and lets the seam go by; as a seam-flat defender in Cover 3 match he carries #2 up the seam first, which turns four verticals from an unsolvable count into four-on-four.
- **Seattle made it an identity.** Carroll's 2010s Seahawks played Cover 3 with a rangy free safety, a box strong safety and long press-bail corners, led the league in scoring defense four years running, and sent coordinators across the league; Bradley's defenses still topped the Cover 3 charts years later.
- **Recognise it by counting.** One high safety, corners off and turned in, a safety near the box before the snap; three deep defenders one second after it.

Connections

Builds on: Coverage Fundamentals (the zone map, deep thirds, spot-drop versus pattern matching, reading the shell) and the concepts drawn against Cover 3 from the offense's side in The Quick Game and Dropback Concepts. The eight-man front connects to the box counts of A First Look at Defense.

Sets up: Cover 2 and Tampa 2 (the two-deep alternative, and the squat corner that cloud borrows), Quarters and the Two-High Match Family (match rules with four deep), and Disguise, Rotation, and Split-Field Coverage (sky, buzz and robber rotations launched from two-high shells). The three-deep, three-under fire zone in Zone Blitzes, Fire Zones, and Simulated Pressure is Cover 3 with a fifth rusher and seam-flat droppers. Run Fits and Box Math builds the run defense the down safety joins, and What Beats What pairs every passing concept with the coverages it beats, Cover 3 first among them.

i Go deeper

- Pete Carroll with Yogi Roth and Kristoffer A. Garin, *Win Forever* (2010): Carroll's philosophy of competition and doing things better than they have ever been done, in the coach's own words.
- Cameron Soran, "The Complete Guide to Nick Saban Coverages at Alabama," Throw Deep Publishing (2021), for how a pattern-matching Cover 3 and its trips checks are taught.
- Chris B. Brown, *The Art of Smart Football* (2015) and the Smart Football archive, for clear essays on Cover 3, pattern matching and four verticals.
- Cody Alexander's MatchQuarters newsletter and his books on match coverage, for the modern coaching language (seam-flat, carry, wall) used in this chapter.
- Coaches' clinic videos on "Cover 3 rotations" (sky, buzz, cloud) and Seattle's press technique are widely available; watching a defensive backs coach teach step-kick for five minutes explains Sherman better than any paragraph.

Answers to Predict the play

Answer 1.

Cover 3 (or its man cousin, Cover 1), with the strong safety rotating down: a sky look. One safety deep in the middle closes the middle of the field; the corners off and outside say zone, deep thirds. The strong safety at 8 yards outside the tight end is the tell: he's the eighth man in the box and the force player against a run to his side, and against a pass he'll come down and out to the curl-flat area. Against 12 personnel on first down the defense is daring the offense to run into eight.

If the offense throws, the soft spots are the ones this chapter drew. **Play-action** first: the safety and linebackers are reading run, so a fake handoff followed by a tight end up the seam, or a deep crossing route behind the linebackers, attacks the exact space the eighth man left. Without a fake, the **hitch** in front of the bailing corners and the **seam** away from the safety's lean are there. The defense accepts all of that in exchange for a run defense with a spare man.

Answer 2.

Probably Cover 3 cloud to the right, with Cover 6 as the other possibility. In a true Cover 2 both corners usually squat in the flats; here only the right one does, and the left one is off at 8 yards in a deep-third alignment. A squatting corner with a safety deep over him on one side and an off corner on the other is the cloud picture: at the snap, the right corner plays the flat, the strong safety runs to the deep right third behind him, and the free safety rotates to the middle. The free safety's alignment helps: he's only about 5 yards from the middle of the field, narrower than a Cover 2 safety (who would be outside the hash), so the deep middle is within his reach.

The same pre-snap picture also fits **Cover 6** (quarters on the left, Cover 2 on the right), whose left side would also have an off corner. **One second after the snap, look at the free safety.** If he runs to the middle of the field, it's three deep: cloud. If he stays on the left and reads the slot receiver, it's two deep: Cover 6. Either way, the right side looks the same, which is the point of the disguise. Against cloud, the place to attack is the deep right third, where a safety has to run with Z.

Answer 3.

The read is the strong safety, the curl-flat defender, and he has sunk under the sail route, so the ball goes to the back in the flat. This is the flood: three receivers at three depths on the right (the go, the sail, the flat) against two defenders, the corner and the curl-flat defender. The corner did his job, staying on top of Z's go route, which leaves the safety alone with two receivers.

He's at about 10 yards, wide, in the window where the sail will arrive, so the back, running to the flat underneath him with nobody within 7 yards, is the throw. Had the safety jumped down toward the flat, the sail behind him would have been open instead.

If this were Cover 3 match, the picture would differ only a little: with #2 (Y) releasing vertically the safety would have carried him at first, and when Y broke out to the sail he'd stay with him, while the Mike, who matches the back (#3), would have a long way to run to the flat. The flat would still be the throw. Flood beats both versions for the same reason. There are only so many defenders on one side of the field.